

Stretching Scenarios

Breaking Constraints to Unlock Better Thinking

Most teams don't struggle with capability. They struggle with the invisible constraints they've stopped questioning.

Overview

One of the most persistent challenges in workshops—particularly when tackling complex, strategic problems—is helping participants move beyond their current mental models. People operate within known constraints: organisational structures, budget cycles, risk appetite, and established processes. These constraints often limit thinking before ideation even begins.

What is Scenario Stretching?

Scenario Stretching involves presenting participants with deliberately challenging, sometimes extreme future scenarios and asking them to respond as though those scenarios are real and unavoidable.

“This scenario is happening—whether you like it or not. What must change for you to succeed?”

Why It Works

- Breaks constraint-based thinking and unlocks new perspectives
- Creates psychological safety through hypothetical framing.
- Forces capability-based thinking around skills, structure, and systems.

Workshop Examples

- Workforce reduced by 50% due to AI – how do you still deliver?
- Planning cycles shift from quarterly to weekly due to volatility.

How to Run It

1. Define 3–5 stretch scenarios
2. Assign to breakout groups
3. Frame with psychological safety
4. Use guiding questions
5. Share and synthesise insights

Outputs

- Future capability gaps
- Workforce evolution insights
- Identification of fragile processes

Supporting Thinking

The use of scenarios to stretch thinking is grounded in established strategy and organisational research. Peter Schwartz's 'The Art of the Long View' explores how scenario planning helps organisations prepare for uncertainty. Amy Edmondson's 'The Fearless Organisation' highlights the importance of psychological safety in enabling teams to think openly and challenge assumptions.

